

171. Chapter 15 Verses 1-4

Lectures by Swami Sarvapriyananda

VERSE 15.1

श्रीभगवानुवाच ।

ऊर्ध्वमूलमधःशाखमश्वत्थं प्राहुरव्ययम् ।

छन्दांसि यस्य पर्णानि यस्तं वेद स वेदवित् ॥१॥

śhrī-bhagavān uvācha

ūrdhva-mūlam adhaḥ-śhākhām aśhvattham prāhur avyayam

chhandānsi yasya parṇāni yas taṁ veda sa veda-vit

śhrī-bhagavān uvācha—the Supreme Divine Personality said; **ūrdhva-mūlam**—with roots above; **adhaḥ**—downward; **śhākhām**—branches; **aśhvattham**—the sacred fig tree; **prāhuḥ**—they speak; **avyayam**—eternal; **chhandānsi**—Vedic mantras; **yasya**—of which; **parṇāni**—leaves; **yaḥ**—who; **taṁ**—that; **veda**—knows; **saḥ**—he; **veda-vit**—the knower of the Vedas

The Lord said: They speak of an imperishable Aśvattha Tree with its root above and branches below. Its leaves are the Vedas, and he who knows it knows the Vedas.

VERSE 15.2

अधश्चोर्ध्वं प्रसृतास्तस्य शाखा
गुणप्रवृद्धा विषयप्रवालाः ।
अधश्च मूलान्यनुसन्ततानि
कर्मानुबन्धीनि मनुष्यलोके ॥ २ ॥

adhaśh chordhvaṁ prasṛitās tasya śhākhā
guṇa-pravṛiddhā viṣhaya-pravālāḥ
adhaśh cha mūlāny anusantatāni
karmānubandhīni manuṣhya-loke

adhaḥ—downward; **cha**—and; **ūrdhvam**—upward; **prasṛitāḥ**—extended; **tasya**—its; **śhākhāḥ**—branches; **guṇa**—modes of material nature; **pravṛiddhāḥ**—nourished; **viṣhaya**—objects of the senses; **pravālāḥ**—buds; **adhaḥ**—downward; **cha**—and; **mūlāni**—roots; **anusantatāni**—keep growing; **karma**—actions; **anubandhīni**—bound; **manuṣhya-loke**—in the world of humans

**Above and below spread its branches, nourished by the
gunas. Sense-objects are its buds; and its clustering roots
spread downward in the world of men, giving rise to action.**

न रूपमस्येह तथोपलभ्यते
नान्तो न चादिर्न च सम्प्रतिष्ठा ।
अश्वत्थमेनं सुविरूढमूल
मसङ्गशस्त्रेण दृढेन छित्त्वा ॥ ३ ॥
ततः पदं तत्परिमार्गितव्यं
यस्मिन्गता न निवर्तन्ति भूयः ।
तमेव चाद्यं पुरुषं प्रपद्ये
यतः प्रवृत्तिः प्रसृता पुराणी ॥ ४ ॥

na rūpam asyeha tathopalabhyate
nānto na chādir na cha sampratishṭhā
aśhvattham enam su-virūḍha-mūlam
asaṅga-śhastreṇa dṛiḍhena chhittvā
tataḥ padaṁ tat parimārgitavyaṁ
yasmin gatā na nivartanti bhūyaḥ
tam eva chādyam puruṣhaṁ prapadye
yataḥ pravṛittiḥ prasṛitā purāṇī

na—not; rūpam—form; asya—of this; iha—in this world; tathā—as such;
upalabhyate—is perceived; na—neither; antaḥ—end; na—nor; cha—also; ādiḥ
—beginning; na—never; cha—also; sampratishṭhā—the basis; aśhvattham—
sacred fig tree; enam—this; su-virūḍha-mūlam—deep-rooted; asaṅga-
śhastreṇa—by the axe of detachment; dṛiḍhena—strong; chhittvā—having cut
down; tataḥ—then; padam—place; tat—that; parimārgitavyam—one must
search out; yasmin—where; gatāḥ—having gone; na—not; nivartanti—return;
bhūyaḥ—again; tam—to him; eva—certainly; cha—and; ādyam—original;
puruṣham—the Supreme Lord; prapadye—take refuge; yataḥ—whence;
pravṛittiḥ—the activity; prasṛitā—streamed forth; purāṇī—very old

Its true form is not comprehended here, nor its end, nor its origin, nor even its existence. Having cut down this firm-rooted Ásvattha with the strong axe of detachment, one should pray, “I take refuge in that Primal Being from whom has streamed forth this eternal activity,” and seek that Goal from which they who have reached it never return.